

The Future of Work & Digital Transformation

Department of Public Service and Administration (DPSA)

03 – 05 March 2026



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CONTEXT AND IMPORTANCE



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Why the Future of Work Matters for Public Service



Impact of Digital Transformation

Digital transformation profoundly affects public service by reshaping work and service delivery in essential sectors.

Challenges in Public Service

Governments face workforce shortages, rising citizen expectations, and complex governance challenges amid rapid change.

Need for Agile Institutions

Public institutions must become agile, resilient, and human-centered to remain effective in a changing world.

Strategic Leadership and Adaptation

Visionary leadership and coordinated action are essential for workforce reskilling and maintaining public trust.



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KEY TRENDS IN PUBLIC SERVICE DIGITAL TRANSFORMATION

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Major Digital Shifts Shaping Government Work



Artificial Intelligence Integration

AI enhances government operations in document processing, decision support, and citizen engagement.

Cloud Compatibility

Cloud ecosystems enable real-time data sharing and improved service delivery across departments.

Cybersecurity Measures

Zero-trust frameworks and continuous monitoring protect public institutions from cyber threats.

Workforce Resilience and Agility

Agile teams adapt rapidly to policy changes and technological advancements in public institutions.



IMPACT OF AUTOMATION

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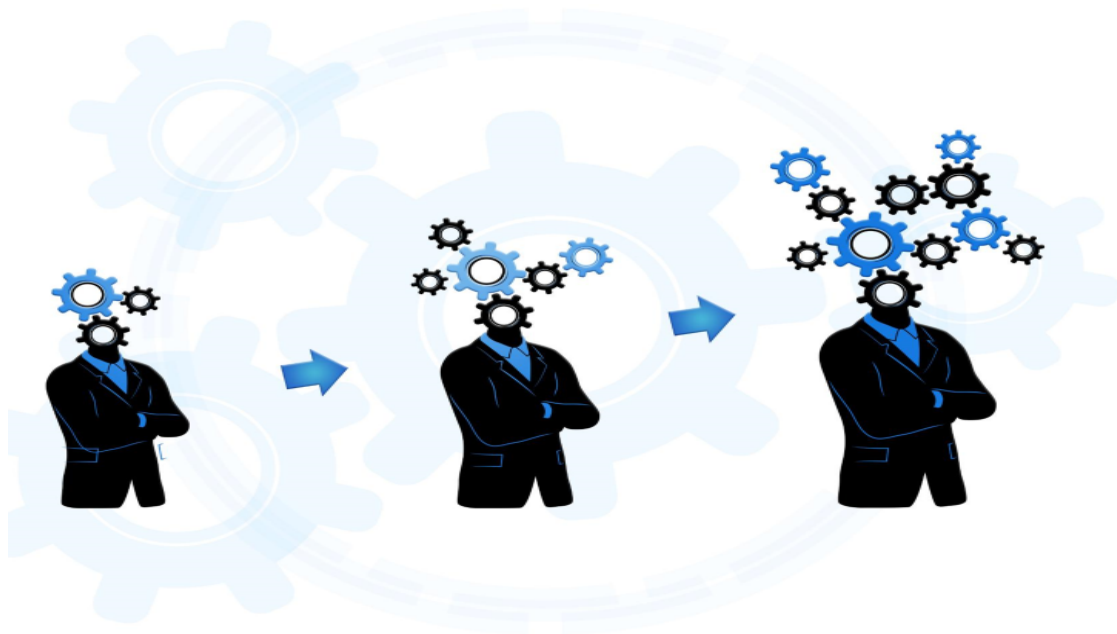


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Automation's Influence on Workflows and Workforce Stability



Task Automation Benefits

Automation handles repetitive tasks, freeing workers to focus on complex, judgment-based activities improving productivity.

Organizational Readiness

Effective automation depends on governance, clear workflows, leadership, and transparency for smooth adoption and efficiency.

Challenges and Concerns

Poorly managed automation can cause resistance, stress, job insecurity, and disrupt workforce stability.

Ethical and Supportive Design

Successful automation requires ethical governance and design that enhances employee roles and service quality.



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LABOUR RELATIONS SHIFTS

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Changing Employment Dynamics and Governance Needs



Evolving Employment Relationships

Work nature shifts with digital transformation, requiring continuous learning, flexible roles, and hybrid work patterns.

Algorithmic Decision Protections

Labour unions advocate for fairness, transparency, and human oversight in algorithmic workplace decisions.

Inclusive Workforce Planning

Policymakers prioritize evidence-based AI adoption and updated labour agreements to protect workers' rights.

Governance for Trust and Equity

Clear governance on automation tools is essential to maintain trust and minimize workforce disruption.



IMPLICATIONS ON LABOUR RELATIONS COLLECTIVE BARGAINING

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MENTAL HEALTH AND PSYCHOSOCIAL WELL-BEING

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- The employer recognises mental health as an increasingly significant workplace issue in digitally enabled environments.
- Digital transformation may increase:
 - Work intensity and pace;
 - Perceived surveillance and performance pressure;
 - Cognitive overload from multiple platforms;
 - Blurring of work-life boundaries, particularly in remote work arrangements.
- In a developing country context, limited access to mental health services heightens these risks. The employer therefore views mental health as a labour relations and sustainability issue, not merely a wellness initiative

SKILLS FOR THE FUTURE

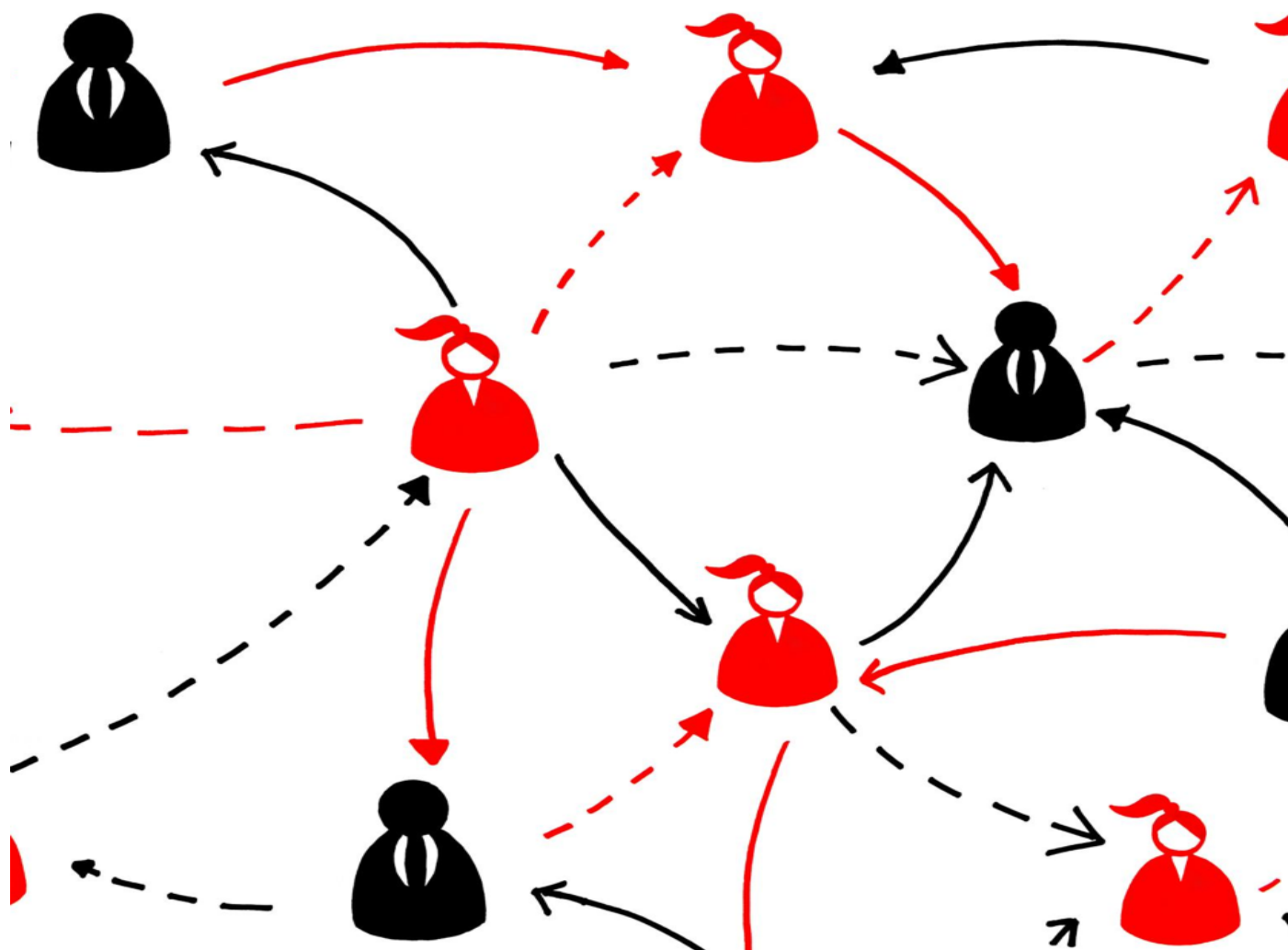
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Technical and Human-Centered Skills for a Digital Public Service

Essential Technical Competencies

AI literacy, data analytics, cybersecurity, and digital systems knowledge equip employees to manage digital tools effectively.

Critical Human-Centered Skills

Adaptability, critical thinking, emotional intelligence, collaboration, and resilience support workforce success amid change.

Modern Workforce Development

Training must shift to skills-based learning with continuous education, reskilling programs, and career mobility pathways.

HUMAN-CENTRIC TRANSFORMATION

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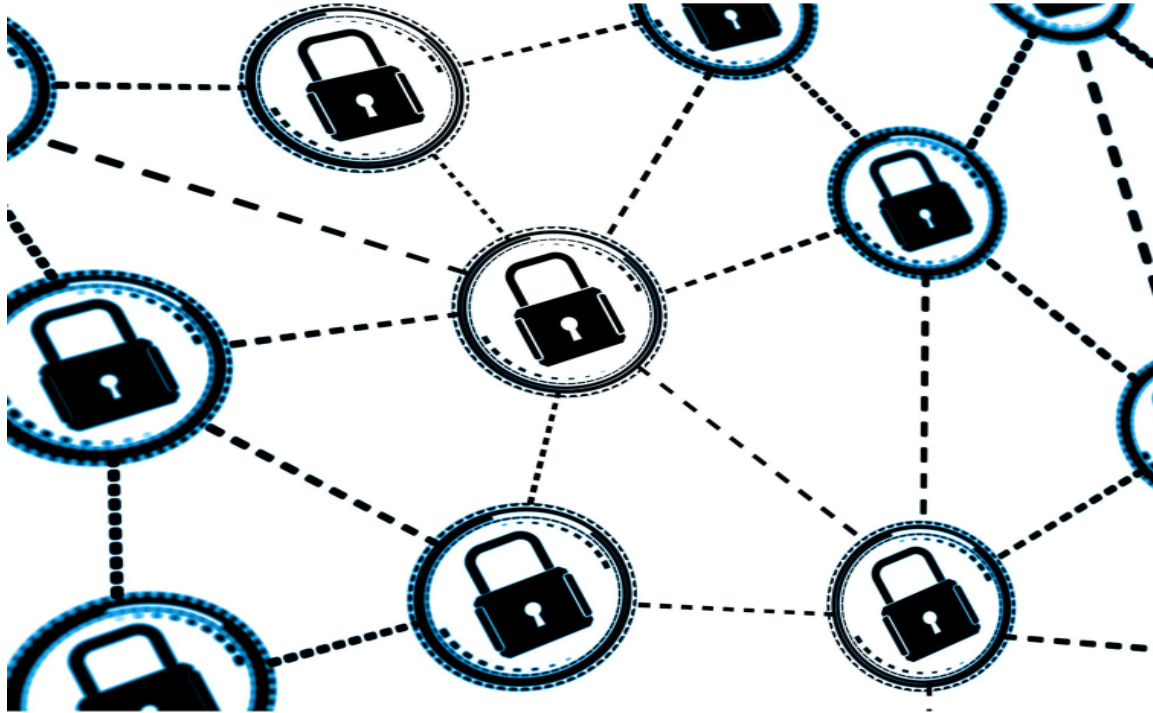


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Prioritizing Public Trust, Ethics, and Employee Experience



Ethical AI and Data Use

Ethical deployment of AI and transparent data use are vital to maintaining trust in public institutions.

Employee Experience Importance

Supporting and empowering employees improves workforce stability and enhances service quality.

Human-Centric Transformation

Human-centered digital transformation emphasizes accountability, empathy, and accessibility in technology.

Protecting Vulnerable Populations

Public service technology decisions must safeguard vulnerable groups and support essential services.



STRATEGIC PRIORITIES FOR LEADERS

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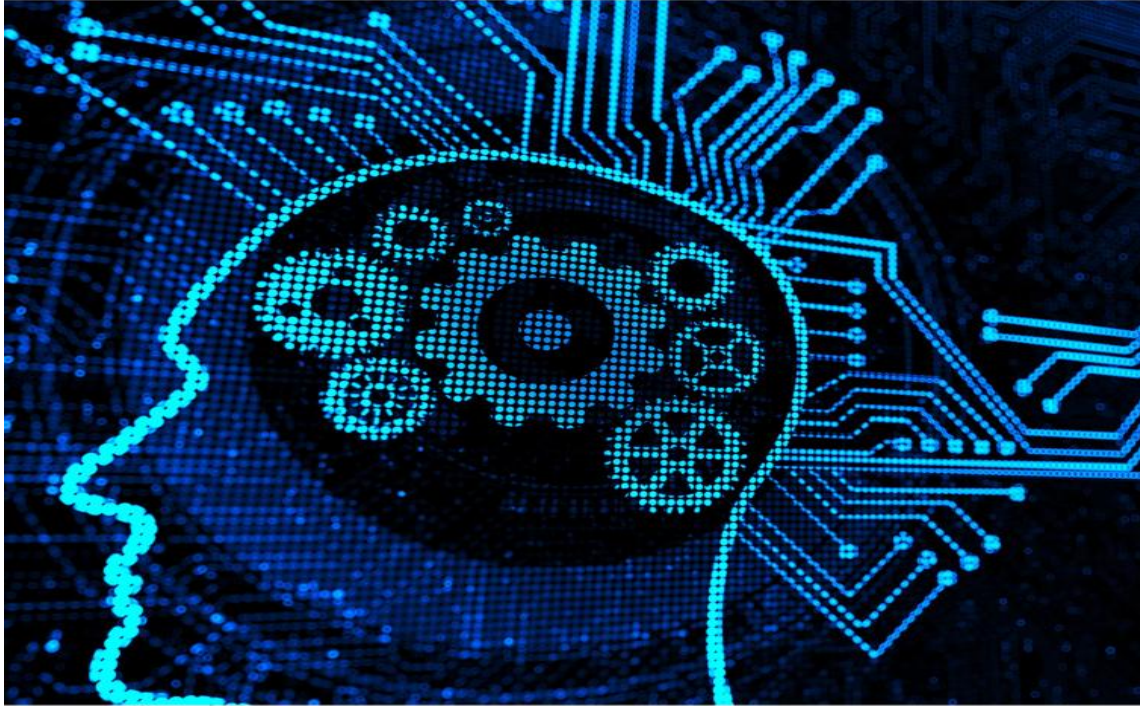


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Guiding Principles for Future-Ready Governance



Reskilling and Workforce Planning

Invest in comprehensive reskilling programs and align workforce planning with future service delivery goals.

Ethical Frameworks for AI

Establish robust ethical frameworks to govern AI and data-driven technologies in the public sector.

Strengthening Digital Infrastructure

Enhance digital infrastructure to support cloud computing, cybersecurity, and interoperable platforms.

Fostering Collaboration and Transparency

Encourage cross-agency collaboration, continuous improvement, and transparent communication on technology changes.



THE ROLE OF LEADERSHIP

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Technology is an enabler, but leadership determines whether digital transformation results in productivity gains, inclusive growth, improved service delivery, or social instability and workforce resistance



Vision & Strategy

Leaders must set a clear, long-term future-of-work vision that aligns digital transformation with organisational and national priorities.

Workforce Transformation

Ensure ethical workforce transitions, with reskilling/upskilling built in before displacement occurs. Embed continuous learning and digital literacy across all levels.

Labour Relations & Trust

Engage labour early and transparently; build trust through social dialogue. Expand bargaining to include AI ethics, skills guarantees, and redeployment.

Culture & Behaviour

Drive a culture of innovation, agility, and collaboration. Leaders must model digital behaviours and data-driven decision-making.

Ethics & Inclusion

Protect human dignity by governing data use, AI, and surveillance fairly. Include older, lower-skilled, and digitally limited workers in transformation efforts.

Leadership Capability

Build new leadership competencies: systems thinking, digital literacy, emotional intelligence, resilience. Empower middle managers to drive local implementation.

Bottom Line

Leadership determines if digital transformation becomes a driver of progress, inclusion, and improved service delivery—or a source of disruption and inequality

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GLOBAL CASE INSIGHTS

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Lessons from International Public-Sector Digital Transformation



UK Automation and Ethics

The UK shows high task automation potential in government with a focus on workforce protection and ethical governance.

Italy's Digital Framework

Italy's framework highlights automation impacts on roles, equity, role restructuring, and recruitment in public administration.

Brazil's Workforce Retraining

Brazil emphasizes large-scale retraining to address automation potential and maintain workforce resilience.

Global Lessons Learned

Data-driven planning, cross-national learning, and proactive adaptation are vital for future public-service work.



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DEVELOPING COUNTRY CONSIDERATIONS

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The employer recognises that digital transformation in a developing country public service must take into account:

- Uneven digital infrastructure and connectivity;
- Skills gaps and historical inequities in training;
- High unemployment and sensitivity to job losses;
- Limited access to specialised mental health services; and
- Strong union presence and expectations of consultation.

Accordingly, the future of work agenda must emphasise managed transition, inclusion, and predictability, rather than rapid disruption.



CALL TO ACTION

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A Forward-Looking Agenda for Public-Service Transformation



People-Centered Modernization

Public-service transformation must focus on people, ethics, and trust to drive meaningful modernization and citizen engagement.

Workforce and System Resilience

Investing in workforce skills and building resilient, agile systems is essential for adapting to rapid digital changes in the public service.

Transparent AI Governance

Establishing transparent governance mechanisms for artificial intelligence ensures ethical use and public trust in emerging technologies.

Inclusive Digital Access

Ensuring equitable access to technological benefits promotes inclusion and democratic values in public services.

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PROPOSED AREAS FOR PSCBC-LED PROJECTS

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- **Public Service Digital Skills Accord**
 - A framework for coordinated reskilling and continuous learning.
- **Technology Impact Assessment Framework**
 - A requirement to assess labour, skills, and mental health impacts prior to major technology implementation.
- **Job Transition and Redeployment Framework**
 - Agreed principles and processes for managing workforce transitions.
- **Remote and Hybrid Work Framework**
 - Guidelines on eligibility, performance management, and work-life boundaries.
- **Mental Health and Digital Well-being Framework**
- Measures to promote psychological safety in digitally enabled workplaces

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